
Will Explore Channel Islands For Relics of Ancient Race

An expedition of scientific students has been made up in California to explore thoroly the channel islands of Santa Barbara and Ventura counties during the next six months. The party is to be sustained by Stanford University largely and to a less extent by several denominational colleges in Southern California. Anthropological and archaeological students who have spent several weeks each on these islands, say they are one of the very richest fields for work in that department of knowledge on the Pacific coast.

The channel islands constitute California's only archipelago, with the possible exception of the rocky and scanty Farallone islands. They have been objects of romance, legends, curiosity and mystery for a generation.

The islands are within 82 miles of California's shore, yet are unfrequented, and years roll by with visits to them of less than 50 persons annually. Each island has its own particular strange, uncanny traditions of the tribes of red men, and each has the countless traces of an occupation

the tribes of red men, and each has the countless traces of an occupation by thousands and thousands of Indians.

When Juan Roderigue Cabrillo, the Portuguese navigator, sailed up the coast of California in 1542, he stopped for a day or two at each of the channel islands, and his records bear testimony that on the islands of Santa Barbara, Catalina, Clemente and St. Nicholas there were a "vigorous and lusty race of natives, who thronged the shores of the little bays and headlands," and gazed in mute wonder at the white-sailed ship of the navigators.

Today the islands stand as they did more than 350 years ago, but the natives are only a memory, represented by immense quantities of stone implements, barrels of fine wampum and cartloads of human bones.

St. Nicholas island lies 80 miles immediately opposite the little city of San Buenaventura (recently called by the more modern and easy name of Ventura) and is the most interest-

by the more modern and easy name of Ventura) and is the most interesting of all the channel islands from many points of view. As far back as the memory of any person in Southern California extends hundreds of white skeletons have dotted the valleys and hillsides. Strange utensils of serpentine sandstone and steatite are found there among the human bones, and the island and its erstwhile inhabitants have a history so curious that it is difficult of comprehension.

In 1855, the Franciscan padres in the Santa Barbara mission, learning that there were but 16 of the strange and almost extinct human race then living there, determined to rescue them from the island. They went over in a sloop and succeeded, as they shot in getting all on board.

At the last moment an Indian woman returned for her child and one of the frequent storms of the channel islands springing up, the sloop was driven away without her. The sloop went on the rocks off Point Concep-

tion and all were lost.

Sixteen years later Captain George Nidever and two men went from the coast on a sloop to hunt otter off St. Nicholas. On landing they were, like Crusoe, astonished to discover human footprints in the sand. They saw no one, however, and a storm compelled them to put to sea. It was two years thereafter that the adventurous captain, revolving in his mind the sight of the footprints on the uncanny island, determined to go to discover and bring over the lonely woman of whom he had vaguely heard. Men accompanied him and at length they saw on the surf-beaten shore a woman with long tawny hair, dressed in a queer garb of colored bird skins and scraping with a bone knife the blubber from a seal. They surrounded and approached her stealthily, and altho suddenly confronted she did not appear in the least afraid but smiled, and then, falling on her knees prayed to the sun. The wild woman offered no objection when by signs she was made to understand that she

Offered no objection when by signs she was made to understand that she was to go with them in the boat.

They reached Santa Barbara across the rough sea, and the first thing the Indian woman saw was a man riding a horse. She had never seen, nor heard of any object like it, and that the man and horse were one, and she knelt on the shore and offered her devotions to it. Two weeks afterward the last inhabitant of rock-ribbed, tempest-tossed St. Nicholas died from eating food to which she was unaccustomed furnished by her rescuers and the curtain fell on her race forever. The woman known as the "Lone Woman of St. Nicholas", has been the subject of a score of romances and poems.

St. Nicholas is ten miles long and four miles wide at the widest point. Its topography shows a nearly level plateau, with an elevation of 800 to 1000 feet. Two-thirds of the surface is covered with drifting sand, and the remainder grows a species of nutritious grass and moss, on which a thousand sheep find pasture.

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As far as the eye can trace there are barren levels with innumerable circular depressions, showing where primitive dwellings once stood. Not a vestige remains of the materials used in the construction of these rancherías. Hundreds of the shell mounds are scattered about and are found to consist of astonishing numbers of mollusca, the bones of every species of fish found in the channel, skeletons of seals, sea elephants, whales, sea otter, the island fox and various aquatic birds.

An examination of some mounds discloses all sorts of curious utensils—stone cooking pots, ollas, shell beads, charm stones, pipes, cups and a few arrowheads, spear points and swords made of bone. The absence of many weapons proves the peaceful attributes of the islanders. Small imitations of boats and fish carved from crystallized talc and serpentine also show a rudimentary knowledge of the art of sculpture.—Dearborn Independent.